



Sharon Carroll Ackerson
(November 16, 1945 – February 10, 2020)

Nels John Ackerson
(April 12, 1944 – March 18, 2025)

Relationship to St. Andrew:

Nels was member of St. Andrew and sang in the choir for six years.

Family:

Children: Stacia (David) Center of Terrace Park, OH
Joshua (Alice) Loveall of Port Charlotte, FL
Betsy Ackerson of Chicago, IL
Peter (Alana) Ackerson of San Francisco, CA

Nine grandchildren

Sisters: Jan Carroll of Los Angeles, CA
Ruth Carroll of South Bend, IN
Karen Jamesen of West Lafayette, IN

Recognitions, Activities, Special Interests:

Sharon: She graduated from South Bend Adams High School in 1964. She received her B.A. from Franklin College in 1968 where she was president of Pi Beta Phi Sorority and was Franklin College's Homecoming queen. She worked as a business development consultant in downtown Indianapolis. She and Nels were married in 1982 and moved to Cairo, Egypt where they and their family lived for three years. In 1985 they moved to Washington, DC where Sharon later became the business manager of their new U.S. law firm. She enjoyed vacationing on Longboat Key, FL, traveling and spending time with friends, her church, and most of all – her family.

Throughout her life Sharon took great pleasure in supporting other people. She was a donor and volunteer for the Salvation Army.

Use of funds: Lafayette Salvation Army.

Obituary:



Sharon Carroll Ackerson

(November 16, 1945-February 10, 2020)

West Lafayette - Sharon Carroll Ackerson, 74, of West Lafayette, IN, passed away on Monday, February 10, 2020 in University Place.

She was born on November 18, 1945 in Dowagiac, Michigan to the late John and Alethea (Nankivell) Carroll. She grew up in South Bend and graduated from South Bend Adams High School in 1964, having spent her summers working for the Salvation Army in Chicago. Sharon received her BA from Franklin College in 1968, where she was president of Pi Beta Phi Sorority and

Franklin College's Homecoming Queen. After college, she was a business development consultant in downtown Indianapolis.

On June 11, 1982, Sharon married Nels Ackerson at the 86th Street United Methodist Church in Indianapolis. Sharon and Nels then moved to Cairo, Egypt, where they and their family lived for 3 years. In 1985 Sharon and Nels and their family moved from Egypt to Washington, DC, where Sharon later became the business manager of their new U.S. law firm.

Sharon enjoyed vacationing on Longboat Key, Florida, traveling and time with friends, her church and-most of all-her family.

Sharon's survivors include her husband, Nels; her children, Stacia (David) Center of Terrace Park, OH and Joshua (Alice) Loveall of Port Charlotte, FL; and her stepchildren, Betsy Ackerson of Chicago, IL, and Peter (Alana) Ackerson of San Francisco, CA. Also surviving are her 9 grandchildren, Campbell, Dane, Jackson, Nicholas, Michael, Mitchell, Anya, Ava, and Maren. Sharon remained close to her sisters-in-law, Jan Carroll of Los Angeles, CA, Ruth Carroll of South Bend, IN, and Karen Jamesen of West Lafayette, IN.

She was preceded in death by her brothers, John Carroll and Paul Carroll.

Visitation will be held on Friday, February 14, 2020 from 1:30 p.m. until 3 p.m. at St. Andrew United Methodist Church (4703 North 50 West, West Lafayette, IN) followed by a farewell service led by Rev. Chris Danielson of St. Andrew Church and Rev. Mia Smith of University Place. Interment, in loving memory of Sharon, will be held on Saturday, February 15, 2020 at 2:30 p.m. at Summit Lawn Cemetery (1154 Westfield Blvd., Westfield, IN)

Memorial donations may be given to the University Place Foundation, St. Andrew United Methodist Church, the Salvation Army or your church or place of worship. You may leave condolences and memories of Sharon at St. Andrew United Methodist Church or online at www.fisherfuneralchapel.com

Nels: He and grew up on a dairy farm in Westfield, IN with his parents and sister, Karen (Jameson). After being active in 4-H and FFA, he enrolled in Purdue where he earned a degree in Agricultural Economics. He was president of the student body, sang in the Glee Club, was IN state president of FFA, and named the G.A. Ross Award for the outstanding senior man. He then earned a Juris Doctor Degree from Harvard where he served as editor of the Harvard Law Review.

He practiced law in Indianapolis and became highly involved in our national government under Senator Birch Bayh. He later established the first American law firm office in Egypt in 1982 where he and his family lived for three years. Upon returning to the United States, he founded his own law firm which gained recognition for successfully litigating on behalf of property owners in eminent domain and property rights cases across the US.

Nels was honored by Purdue University as a distinguished alumnus and was conferred with honorary Doctor of Agriculture degree. After retiring, he enjoyed spending time with family in their home in Longboat Kay, FL. Nels and Sharon moved to West Lafayette and lived in University Place.

Use of Funds: to be determined

Obituary:



Nels John Ackerson

(April 12, 1944 - March 18, 2025)

Nels Ackerson, a distinguished American attorney and advocate for property rights, passed away on March 18, 2025, at the age of 80. Born on April 12, 1944, in Eagletown, Indiana, Nels was the son of a farmer and a teacher, and the grandson of Swedish immigrants. He grew up on his family's dairy farm in

Westfield, Indiana, where he attended Westfield public schools, actively participated in 4-H and other youth organizations, and graduated as class president and valedictorian.

Nels pursued higher education at Purdue University, earning a Bachelor of Science degree with distinction in Agricultural Economics. During his time at Purdue, he served as student body president and was honored with the G. A. Ross Award as the most outstanding male graduate. He was also a member of the FarmHouse fraternity, the Purdue Glee Club and held the position of Indiana State President of the Future Farmers of America (FFA) during his freshman year. In his sophomore year, Nels was elected National FFA President, a role in which he presided over the desegregation of the FFA and the New Farmers of America (NFA), marking a significant step toward inclusivity in agricultural organizations.

Continuing his academic journey, Nels earned a Juris Doctor degree with distinction from Harvard Law School, where he served as an editor of the Harvard Law Review. He also obtained a Master in Public Policy from Harvard's John F. Kennedy School of Government, as part of the inaugural class of the joint degree program.

Nels's legal career was both diverse and impactful. He began practicing law at Barnes, Hickam, Pantzer & Boyd in Indianapolis, later serving as Chief Counsel and Executive Director of the U.S. Senate Subcommittee on the Constitution under Senator Birch Bayh. In this capacity, he played a pivotal role in legislative efforts such as the Equal Rights Amendment and the proposed Direct Election Amendment to abolish the Electoral College. Nels also contributed to the development of biofuel incentives and co-authored the Bayh–Dole Act, which allowed universities and small businesses to patent inventions arising from federally funded research, thereby fostering innovation and economic growth.

Demonstrating a global perspective, Nels established the first American law firm office in Egypt in 1982, partnering with distinguished Egyptian lawyer Gamal Naguib to form Sidley & Austin & Naguib. He was a founding member and president of the American Chamber of Commerce in Egypt and served on the board of the Bilateral Fulbright Commission, reflecting his commitment to international development and cooperation.

In 1991, Nels founded his own law firm, Ackerson Kauffman Fex, which gained recognition for successfully litigating on behalf of property owners in eminent domain and property rights cases across the United States. His firm's landmark cases were featured in prominent publications such as The Wall Street Journal and The New York Times, underscoring his dedication to justice and the protection of individual rights.

Nels's contributions to agriculture and law were acknowledged by Purdue University, which honored him as a distinguished alumnus and conferred upon him an honorary Doctor of Agriculture degree, citing his "legal accomplishments that will have lasting impact on landowner rights."

Upon retirement, he found great joy in spending time with his family at their home on Longboat Key, Florida. Whether walking along the white sandy beaches, enjoying breathtaking sunsets over the Gulf of Mexico, or hosting family gatherings filled with laughter and love, Longboat Key was a cherished retreat where he created many lasting memories with his loved ones.

A devout Christian, Nels was a member of St. Andrew United Methodist Church. He enjoyed singing in their choir. For the past six years, he resided in West Lafayette, Indiana, at University Place, a senior living community. He was preceded in death by his beloved wife, Sharon. Nels is survived by his four children, their spouses and nine grandchildren. He is also survived by his sister, niece, nephew, and their spouses and children. His legacy as a devoted family man, a passionate advocate for justice, and a pioneer in both national and international legal arenas will be remembered and cherished by all who knew him.

In lieu of flowers, the family requests that donations be made to the Purdue Foundation, reflecting Nels's lifelong commitment to his alma mater.

Visitation will be from 10:am until time of funeral service at 11:00 am, Friday, March 21, 2025, at St. Andrew's United Methodist Church with Rev. Wellington Chiomadzi officiating.

Interment will be at 2:00 pm, Friday, March 21, 2025, at Summit Cemetery in Westfield.